

EQUIPPED POLICE FORCE AND SHOW ENOUGH POLITICAL WILL TO CONTAIN THE BARBARISM

EVEN AS THEY ADDRESS THE SOCIAL ISSUES RAISED BY THE MAOISTS

THIN



■ By Amarnath K. Menon

It is sub-rural terror masquerading as revolution. Taking full advantage of the stoic passivity of a soft state, it has become the biggest killing machine of the country. Exactly 40 years after the sanguineous extremists led by Charu Mazumdar and Kanu Sanyal launched the armed movement in the nondescript Naxalbari village of Darjeeling in West Bengal, violent campaign continues unabated in the wretched remoteness of India. Left wing extremism (LWE) or Naxalism has killed thousands of people to emerge as an immediate threat to internal security. Worse still, more than a year after Prime Minister Manmohan Singh acknowledged the severity of this threat by calling it the "single biggest internal security challenge ever faced by our country", there is no holistic initiative to tackle the bloodlust.

The militants, who launched an armed movement in 1967 claiming to fight for the rights of poor peasants and landless labourers, are active in at least 16 of the country's 33 states. What was confined initially to pockets in West Bengal and Andhra Pradesh in the early 1970s has not only spread in a virulent manner but emerged as a major political force in the tribal woods of Chhattisgarh, Orissa and Jharkhand. They strike at will with accurate planning, ambush police teams, break into jails and hit select targets to create a fear psychosis as is the wont of terror groups everywhere. Despite the improvement of the information gathering networks in the affected areas, the range and intensity of the Maoist violence spirals upwards.

In one recent incident, the outlaws massacred 18 people including former Jharkhand chief minister Babul Marandi's son in the Chikhari village of the state's Giridih district. Earlier in March last year, 350 armed Maoists overran the Rani Bodli police outpost in Chhattisgarh's Dantewada region. Before that, they had murdered Sunil Mahato, a Jharkhand Mukti Morcha MP, on March 4. This was the first time that an MP was murdered. In the same month, a few hundreds of militants led simultaneous attacks on a police station, a block office and a branch of the Central Bank of India at Riga in Bihar's Sitamarhi district. They smuggled the arms on vegetable-laden carts into Riga days before the operation. Their 'area commanders' coordinated the attack by using China-made Motorola walkie-talkie sets. The police, obviously, had little clue. The change in their strategies suggests that the Maoists have now turned their attention to regions where big projects in mining, irrigation or industrialisation have been planned or are underway.

At their 'Unity Congress' last year, the cpi(Maoist) general secretary Muppala Lakshmana Rao had reportedly declared, "Time has come to spread in the towns and identify specific targets, hit them precisely and with impunity." A statement issued after the meeting in February stated that "the Unity Congress has resolved to advance the people's war through-

TARGET PRACTICE: Naxalites are now planning to take the people's war to urban areas especially industrial towns